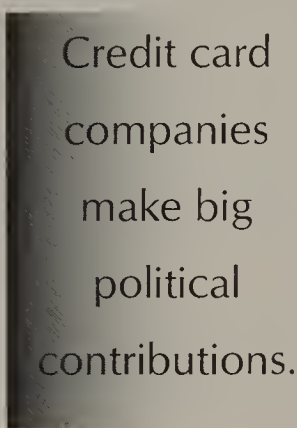


want to be sure to protect is their ability to go out and sell credit cards when they don't have to tell what the terms are, and they can change the terms after someone has taken out the debt."



Credit card
companies
make big
political
contributions.

No other industry has that ability. The words that come to my mind are "crooks" and "shysters." The Consumer Credit Hearings of 2005 were a sham. The practices of the consumer lending industry were supposed to be reviewed by a Congressional committee, but the members of Congress had a more important vote to get to, or a doughnut waiting, or something like that. In the feature film documentary *Maxed Out*, some of the credit card industry representatives from various

major banks are shown making their pretty statements into their microphones to the effect of, "Gosh, we're really great. We give credit cards to people and we are wonderful." No questions were posed to them, and that was the end of the hearing. Nothing happened. No debates. No discussions. No proposals of legislation or guidance. Nothing at all happened. What is the point of a hearing if you do not ask any questions? I'm still scratching my head over that one.

The Facts in Black and White

Think of how we buy on credit. Most of us cannot plunk down a full cash payment for our houses or our cars. We have to pay them off over time, and we have to pay a little interest for doing so. That is a no-brainer. It is also accepted as a no-brainer that we know what we are going to pay.

For every contract, except for credit cards, the terms are stated up front and do not change. When Ed and Sue bought their house, there was a statement that they were given called "truth in lending." They were shown the amount that they were borrowing, the interest rate, and how much total interest they would pay over the life of the loan.

Most of us cringe when we see that total figure, but it is put before our eyes, so we are aware of what we are paying over the life of the loan.